



Dried star anise fruit is a digestive, stimulant, and diuretic remedy.

Constituents Star anise contains a volatile oil (mostly anethole), sesquiterpenoids, and flavonoids, including quercetin. Anethole calms the digestive system and relieves gas. The sesquiterpenoids have analgesic activity. Shikimic acid, found in the seed pods, was until recently used as the main source for the production of Tamiflu, a prescribed anti-viral medicine.

History & Folklore Due to its high anethole content, star anise has a similar taste to anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248), and both are used principally as spices. The herb's Chinese name, *ba jiao hui xian*, means "8-horned fennel."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Used in Chinese herbal medicine as a remedy for rheumatism, back pain, and hernias, star anise has stimulant, diuretic, and digestive properties. It makes an effective remedy for gas and indigestion—especially colic—and can safely be given to children. To treat hernias of the intestine or bladder, star anise is often mixed with fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212). Both herbs help to relax the organ's muscles and relieve spasm. Star anise is also used for toothache.

Caution Japanese star anise (*Illicium anisatum*), which is very similar to star anise, contains a toxic compound and can cause serious side effects.

Imperatoria ostruthium, syn.
Peucedanum ostruthium

Masterwort

Description Perennial growing to 2 ft (60 cm) with green leaves divided into 3 leaflets with 3 lobes, white flowers on large umbels, and winged seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to central and southern Europe and Asia, most often found in the wild. The root is unearthed in autumn or spring.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Masterwort contains a camphoraceous volatile oil (including limonene, phellandrene, alpha-pinene, and a sesquiterpene), peucedanin, oxipeucedanin, and ostrutol.

History & Folklore From the late Middle Ages onward, masterwort was held in high regard

by herbalists. Pierandrea Matteoli's *Materia Medica* of 1548 explains: "Masterwort powerfully resolves all flatulence in the body, stimulates urine and menstruation, is an admirable remedy for paralysis and cold conditions of the brain, and helps against pestilence and the bites of rabid dogs." A century later, Nicholas Culpeper was no less fulsome in recommending masterwort for rheumatic conditions, shortness of breath, kidney and bladder stones, water retention, "falling sickness," and wounds.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Masterwort is little used today, but it may well be an herb that bears further investigation. The root is aromatic, warms central areas of the body, and is a bitter tonic. It has a strong action within the stomach and gut, settling indigestion and relieving gas and cramping. Masterwort is also beneficial for chest conditions, and is used for colds, asthma, and bronchitis. It can also be helpful for menstrual problems.

Caution If applied to the skin, masterwort may cause an allergic reaction to sunlight.

Ipomoea purga syn. *Convolvulus jalapa* (Convolvulaceae)

Jalap

Description Evergreen vine reaching about 13 ft (4 m). Has heart-shaped leaves and trumpet-like purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Mexico, jalap is cultivated in Central America, the West Indies, and Southeast Asia. The root is unearthed in summer.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Jalap contains the resin convolvulin.

History & Folklore Spanish colonizers learned of jalap's strong purgative effect from Mexican native peoples. Introduced into Europe in 1565, the herb was used for all types of illnesses until the 19th century.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Jalap is such a powerful cathartic that its medicinal value is questionable. Even in moderate doses it stimulates the elimination of profuse watery stools, and in larger doses it causes vomiting.

Related Species *I. turpethum*, native to Asia and Australia, is also a drastic purgative. Other *Ipomoea* species, such as the sweet potato (*I. batatas*, from South America), are important food plants. The seeds of morning glory (*I. violacea*), native to Mexico, contain compounds similar to LSD, and were taken ritually by the Zapotecs and Aztecs.

Caution Do not take jalap under any circumstances.

Iris versicolor (Iridaceae)

Blue Flag, Wild Iris

Description Perennial growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has erect stems and long sword-shaped leaves. Each stem bears 3–5 resplendent blue to violet flowers with white-veined areas on the petals.

Habitat & Cultivation Blue flag is native to North America. Preferring damp and marshy areas in the wild, it is also widely cultivated as a garden plant. The rhizome is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Blue flag contains triterpenoids, salicylic, and isophthalic acids, a very small amount of volatile oil, starch, resin, an oleoresin, and tannins.

History & Folklore Blue flag was one of the medicinal plants most frequently used by Native Americans. Different tribes made use of it variously as an emetic, cathartic, and diuretic, to treat wounds, and for colds, earache, and cholera. In the Anglo-American Physiomedicalist tradition, blue flag was used as a glandular and liver remedy. Blue flag is Quebec's provincial flower.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Blue flag is currently used mainly to detoxify the body. It increases urination and bile production, and has a mild laxative effect. This combination of cleansing actions makes it a useful herb for chronic skin diseases such as acne and eczema, especially where gallbladder problems or constipation contribute to the condition. Blue flag is also given for biliousness and indigestion. However, in large doses blue flag will itself cause vomiting. The traditional use of blue flag for gland problems persists. It is also believed by some to aid weight loss.

Cautions Excessive doses cause vomiting. Do not take this plant during pregnancy.



Blue flag was very widely used by Native Americans to treat wounds and sores.